



Doomsday PROPHECIES

A graphic novel blends Aesop's fables and Orwell's dystopia in a saga of greed and destruction

By Saurabh Singh



MOONWARD
by APPUPEN
Blaft
Price: Rs 335
Pages: 272

It doesn't get any more serious than this. Modern civilisation is under the spell of a monster and is being led by the finger towards a disastrous culmination. The author, in his debut attempt, raises alarm by narrating this saga of greed and destruction, a grotesque fairytale loaded with symbolism and apocalyptic predictions. The story of creation doomed from the start, encounters monsters and tyrants every turn, and everything, from the philosophy of religion to the quagmire of an artist, is brought up in this graphic novel.

Like every epic, this one too starts from the start. In the beginning, there was nothing... But no sooner, a blob of existence emerged on the scene; he finds the garden of Eden already booby-trapped. A wise tortoise sheltered under an ancient tree tries to bring in order and morality amongst a bewildered lot of creatures and unknowingly sets of a chain

reaction of unfortunate events.

It is difficult to miss the message when the symbol of corruption is an upright hand, palm facing front, fingers at attention. An inscription at the base mentions "the prophit" and horrific acts are carried out under the guidance of the "Hand" later. Trees are milked for their tears, which a valuable commodity. An artist who paints with his own blood finds himself incapable of bleeding, and thus incapable of painting, once his soul is corrupted by lust for money. The frail plant that gives birth to a bulbous top heavy pumpkin like fruit which bears cola bottles for seeds is an apt metaphor for human greed. An amalgam of Aesop's fables and Orwell's dystopia, *Moonward* tells the fatalistic nature of human desires. At one point, Man leaves in search of an answer for the mountain top and meditates where he is granted a flash of enlightenment. His future self, a portly version of his emaciated present condition tunes in, not unlike a TV broadcast, and preaches the love of money and the pleasures of power. Almost every page is loaded with symbolism, sometimes inventive and sometimes tired rhetoric. ■

Trapped LIVES

A cage girl's diary comes too close to reality

By Sonya Dutta Choudhury

Batuk is nine years old when her family throws her a going-away party. "Everyone there, except me, knew that I was leaving" she tells us. But because the party was "a gathering of people who were all uneasy", Batuk thinks she must be terminally ill and being taken to Mumbai for treatment. The truth is almost more tragic—for the little girl, bubbly and bright, is being sold into prostitution.

The blue notebook is her diary, the little scribbles she carefully records whenever she can; in her cage on Common Street, in the bathroom, in the Tiger Suite of a luxurious hotel. She tells us of "making sweetcake" with as many as 10 men a day, men who will touch her "bunny rabbit", and of others who will auction her and abuse her.

Batuk weaves to and fro in this slim and simple narrative. She tells us, in her matter-of-fact way, of her friend Puneet, whose life turns tragic when he grows out of his little boy looks, and has to be castrated. She tells us of the price she pays for being pretty, and how that leads to her being "bought" for Ifrikhar, the sadistic rich kid of an industrialist to teach him "how to be a husband".

It's a sad sad story, more so for being so appallingly close to real life. *The Blue Notebook* is regrettably no flight of fancy. Indeed, doctor-writer James A. Levine has based it on actual conversations with cage girls in Mumbai. ■



THE BLUE NOTEBOOK
by JAMES A. LEVINE
Weidenfeld & Nicolson
Price: Rs 250
Pages: 206